

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

QA Onboarding Checklist

Get a new QA engineer productive, connected and confident across their first 90 days — without overwhelming them on day one.

Purpose

Onboarding is where a good hiring decision is either realised or wasted. This checklist structures a new QA engineer's first 90 days so they gain access, context and relationships in a sensible order — and so their manager, not the new starter, owns the plan. A strong first three months turns a promising hire into a contributing team member; a chaotic one turns them into a flight risk.

When to use it

- From the moment an offer is accepted — pre-arrival preparation is part of onboarding.
- For every new QA hire, adapted to their level and specialism.
- As a shared document between the new starter, their manager and their buddy, reviewed at 30, 60 and 90 days.

Instructions

1. Assign a named buddy before day one — someone other than the manager for day-to-day questions.
2. Sequence learning: context and relationships first, meaningful contribution second. Do not drop the hardest problem on them in week one.
3. Give an early, safe, real win — something shippable and low-risk — to build confidence and momentum.
4. Check in deliberately at 30/60/90 days against the checklist, not just when something goes wrong.
5. Treat completion as the new starter's success being visible to the team, not as a box-ticking exercise for HR.

Worked example

An onboarding plan for Northstar's new Senior QA Engineer (Automation & CD). Buddy: Sofia Alvarez. Deliberately, the flaky Selenium suite — the reason they were hired — is studied in month one but not owned until they have context, so they change it from understanding rather than on day three.

Pre-arrival

- Laptop, accounts and tooling requested (Jira, repo, CI, staging) so nothing is blocked on day one.

- Buddy (Sofia) and manager 1:1s booked in the calendar in advance.
- A written first-week plan shared before they start, so the unknown feels smaller.
- Team told who is joining, when, and why — so they are welcomed, not a surprise.

Week 1 — context and belonging

- Access confirmed working end to end (can run the app, view the pipeline, open a ticket).
- Met the QA team (Sofia, Dan, Ravi, Grace, Hassan, Emma) and understands who does what.
- Walked the products (web SPA, mobile app, public API) and the payments/legacy-billing landscape at a high level.
- Shadowed a release and seen the 5-day regression pass first-hand — the problem they are here to help with.
- One small, safe first contribution merged (e.g. fixing a single flaky test with Dan pairing).

Days 30 — orientation complete

- Understands the current automation suite, its structure and its main pain points.
- Has paired with Dan on the suite and with an exploratory tester on a squad.
- Understands each squad's "definition of done" and where they differ.
- Has met key stakeholders beyond QA (Priya, VP Eng; a squad lead — including the QA-sceptical Marcus).
- 30-day check-in held: what is clear, what is confusing, what is blocked.

Days 60 — contributing

- Owns a defined slice of the automation work with a clear first improvement in flight.
- Running the fortnightly automation clinic jointly with Dan, beginning to spread ownership.
- Trusted to test independently within at least one squad.
- 60-day check-in held against the role's 3-month success measures.

Days 90 — established

- Delivered a visible improvement (e.g. the worst flaky tests stabilised or removed).
- At least one other engineer now more confident in the suite thanks to their coaching.
- Working relationship established even with the sceptics; seen as a help, not an overhead.
- 90-day review: confirm the hire is on track, set the first IDP, agree the next quarter's focus.

How to interpret the results

- Onboarding is going well when the new starter is asking sharper questions over time and needing the buddy less — not when every box is ticked on schedule.
- A confident early contribution matters more than speed. Someone shipped a real fix in week one and understands why beats someone who has read every document and touched nothing.
- If they are still blocked on access or unclear on their remit at 30 days, that is a management failure, not a slow hire — fix it before it becomes a retention problem.
- A weak first 90 days predicts a short tenure. Treat this checklist as protecting the hiring investment you just made, not as paperwork.

Blank reusable version

- Pre-arrival: equipment and access requested · buddy assigned · 1:1s booked · first-week plan shared · team informed.

- Week 1: access verified · met the team · product & architecture walkthrough · shadowed a release · first safe contribution.
- Day 30: understands the systems · paired across roles · knows each team's definition of done · met key stakeholders · 30-day check-in.
- Day 60: owns a defined slice of work · contributing to team improvement · testing independently · 60-day check-in.
- Day 90: delivered a visible win · helping others grow · relationships established · 90-day review and first IDP set.

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Access and tooling not ready on day one, so the first week is wasted waiting. Dropping the hardest problem (the flaky suite) on someone before they have any context. No buddy, so every trivial question has to go to the manager. Death by documentation with no real contribution for weeks. Skipping the 30/60/90 check-ins until something is already wrong. Treating onboarding as HR's job rather than the manager's.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Engineer one genuine, shippable win in the first week — even a single flaky test fixed with a colleague pairing. Nothing builds a new hire's confidence, or the team's confidence in them, faster than an early contribution they can point to and say "I did that".